relaxing vacation I've ever had but I loved every minute of it: traveling around on the tour bus, hanging out with Victoria in luxurious hotel rooms and then, every night, going to watch one of those amazing concerts.

On that first night at Madison Square Garden, I remember watching Victoria up there on stage, in front of a packed audience at one of the world's great venues, looking and sounding so good and, at the same time—in the middle of all the lights and noise and thousands of people jumping up and down—there was a little quiet place, all mine, where I knew Victoria had our baby inside her. I had that first picture of Brooklyn in my mind all evening long.

Maybe I'd been leading a charmed life until that summer in 1998. What disappointments had I really had to face until then? I'd grown up dreaming about playing for Manchester United and the dream had come true. No sooner had I got to Old Trafford, I was in the first team with this inspired group of boys my own age and we were winning championships and cups. And then, almost overnight, I'd had the call to play for England and been part of getting my country through to the finals of the most important tournament of all. In hindsight, perhaps luck had run for me. I hadn't had much practice dealing with the big knocks, the kind of blows I had to take that June. I know how disappointed the England players and fans were that night in Saint-Etienne. At the eye of the storm, I was crushed by what had happened too. What I wasn't ready for, at 23 years of age, was for all the blame for defeat against Argentina to be laid just on me.

My life, like anybody else's, has been full of lessons to be learned. The difference that comes with a career as a high-profile soccer player, with every move fixed in the public eye, is that I've had less margin for error and less time in which to come to terms with my mistakes. That isn't something I can complain about, because the same whirlwind that blew through my life as a result of me being sent off against Argentina, could also blow me across the Atlantic into the arms of the woman—the Girl—that I loved. Twenty-four hours after the worst moment I could ever have imagined, I was at Madison Square Garden, with a grainy hospital Polaroid in my pocket, as excited and as happy as any lad could ever be. One night, my life was falling to pieces on a soccer field in France. The next, despite that hurt, I was just letting the best feeling of all sink in: I was going to be a dad. I couldn't have known what was waiting for me back home in England, or how I'd have to deal with it all. But if I was going to be a father for that little speck of a new life in Victoria's scan, now had to be the time for me to learn to be a man.